Open Knowledge for a Sustainable Future: Research, Ethics, and Wikipedia

Week 3 — Academic vs Encyclopedic Writing: what is your message?

Francis Bond (**Academic**) Pavel Bednařík (Wiki)

Palacký University Olomouc | Wikimedia ČR

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2. What is your message?
3. How can you convince people?

Roadmap

1. Why should we write?
   - Reading for Writing
2. What is your message?
3. How can you convince people?

Why Write?

- Writing is a tool for thinking as well as a means of communication
- It clarifies ideas, interprets texts, and joins a scholarly conversation
- Written work demonstrates:
  - Understanding of key issues
  - Ability to argue persuasively
  - Awareness of disciplinary methods
- Writing is a way of finding out what you think

Partly based on Analyzing Texts, Taking Notes (Allosso & Allosso, 2019, Ch. 1)

Humanities, Social Sciences, and Linguistics

- All three study human experience, culture, society and language
- **Humanities:**
  - Interpret texts, artworks, languages, and histories
  - Value close reading, interpretation, argumentation
- **Social Sciences:**
  - Study human behavior, institutions, and systems
  - Employ observation, evidence, and models
- **Linguistics:** a bridge between the two, both theoretical and empirical
  - General: structure and use of language
  - Variation & change: sociolinguistics, dialectology, historical linguistics
  - Mind & processing: psycholinguistics, neurolinguistics
  - Data & methods: corpora, fieldwork/elicitation, experiments, formal modeling
  - Technology & applications: computational linguistics/NLP, lexicography, language documentation
- All rely on critical analysis, evidence, and writing suited to the audience and genre

Writing as Inquiry

- Writing generates ideas and sharpens questions
- Early drafts explore; conclusions come later
- Revision is discovery: each draft deepens understanding
- Balance open exploration with a focused argument
- Thinking happens through writing, not before it

Academic Conversations

- Academic writing joins a conversation that started before you
- You engage with others by:
  - Quoting and analyzing sources
  - Summarizing and synthesizing prior work
  - Acknowledging different viewpoints
- An essay responds to that conversation and adds to it
- Citations give credit for others' work, and let readers check it

Voice and Style

- Academic writing has a clear, confident voice
- Strive for:
  - Precision over ornamentation
  - Clarity over complexity
  - Variety in sentence structure
- Avoid jargon unless necessary
- Use active verbs and concise phrasing
- Essays need a logical progression of ideas
  - Use an outline to keep on track
  - Check that every section supports the thesis

Revising and Editing

- Revision works on the ideas; editing works on the words
- Strategies:
  - Read aloud to test clarity
  - Seek peer or instructor feedback
  - Review argument flow
  - Cut redundancy
- Proofread before you submit

Academic Integrity

- Cite every idea you borrow
- Keep detailed notes on sources
- A paraphrase restates the idea in your own words; swapping a few words is still copying
- Readers trust work when they can see where it came from

Reading for Writing

- Writing starts with reading and taking notes
- Treat every lecture, discussion and reading as a text to analyse
- Keep asking questions as you read
- Take notes you can turn into arguments later
- Work out how the text does what it does, as well as what it says

Partly based on Analyzing Texts, Taking Notes (Allosso & Allosso, 2019, Ch. 1)

What Counts as a Text?

- Anything you meet in class: readings, lectures, discussions
- Analyse them all the time, not only when told to
- Compare new material with prior readings, lectures, and beliefs
- Write your thoughts down: notes are the start of the essay

Active Reading Mindset

- Break the text into parts: what is each one for?
- Notice plot, imagery, symbolism and allusion (not only in literature)
- Nonfiction uses these tools too
- Read for patterns as well as facts
- Taking apart other people's writing teaches you to build your own

Questions to Drive Analysis

- What confuses you? What needs clarification?
- Which claims are most central to the text's project?
- How do structure and language support those claims?
- What assumptions or premises are in play?
- How does this text relate to other course materials and your concerns?

For Fiction (Mostly)

- **Narrator**: who tells the story? reliable/unreliable/biased?
- **Setting & tone**: what senses and emotions are evoked?
- **Characters**: motivations, loyalties, whom you side with
- **Language/diction**: level and implications
- **Plot/structure**: problems, challenges, archetypes
- **Images/motifs**: repetitions, metaphors, patterns
- **Ending**: what resolves? why end there?

For Nonfiction (Mostly)

- **Author**: background and qualifications
- **Audience**: allies, opponents, or neutral readers?
- **Intention**: explanatory, polemical, celebratory? Why was it written?
- **Structure**: how is the argument organized?
- **Appeals**: logic vs. emotion; what types of arguments are used?

On Arguments: Classical Roots

- Aristotle's analysis of argument still works
- Logic is central to many, but not all, arguments
- A **syllogism** shows how accepted premises force a conclusion
- Premises can be disputed
- Most real reasoning gives only probable conclusions

Deduction

- From accepted premises to a conclusion that must follow
  - All data centres use water; this is a data centre; so it uses water
- If the premises hold, the conclusion holds
- Works when everyone accepts the same facts and definitions
- Limit: most debates are about the premises
- So state your premises, and test them

Induction

- From observations to a generalisation
  - Three data centres in Arizona use a lot of water; so data centres in dry places use a lot of water (how many did you check?)
- Conclusions are tentative (we never observe everything)
- Even strong theories can be revised
- Good induction follows the data
- Match the strength of the claim to the evidence

Narrative as Argument

- Stories persuade because we identify with the people in them
- History blends data, concepts, and narrative structure
- Narrative sometimes stands in for data
- When a writer tells a story, ask what work it is doing

Reason, Emotion, and Premises

- Separate appeals to reason from appeals to emotion
- Trace the path from premises to conclusion
- Test premises for assumptions, generality, and evidence
- Where is the uncertainty: in the data, the inference, or the values?

Note-Taking Checklist

- Capture the central question and main claims
- Mark evidence and how it supports claims
- Flag key terms, metaphors, and recurring motifs
- Record questions and possible counterarguments
- Boil it down to one or two sentences you can use later

Roadmap

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What Is a Thesis?

- A thesis is a claim that can be defended with reasons and evidence
- It is neither a topic nor a fact, but an interpretation
- Example:
  - Topic: “Women in Shakespeare”
  - Thesis: “Shakespeare’s comedies use disguise to challenge gender norms”
- It is a promise to the reader about where the essay goes

Partly based on Creating a Thesis (Allosso & Allosso, 2019, Ch. 3)

From Question to Argument

- Start with a question you want answered
- Narrow it until it can be answered in the space you have
- Ask: how? why? so what?
- Your first answer is the working thesis
- Revise the thesis as new evidence appears

Characteristics of a Strong Thesis

- **Debatable**: reasonable people could disagree
- **Specific**: not a vague generality
- **Focused**: answerable in the space you have
- **Insightful**: says something not already obvious
- **Connected**: matches the evidence you have

Weak — announces a topic	**Strong** — takes a stance
"This essay will discuss social media and teenagers."	"Social media intensifies teenage anxiety by rewarding performative identity."
"This essay will discuss data centres and water."	"Data centre water use is small nationally but heavy locally, so it should be reported by watershed."

A strong thesis makes the reader ask **how?** and **why?**

Refining Your Thesis

- An early thesis is a rough hypothesis
- Strengthen by:
  - Clarifying key terms
  - Tightening scope
  - Checking consistency with evidence
- Ask a classmate to summarise your claim: is that what you meant?
  - **That is what we are about to do with your water paragraphs**

Common Pitfalls

- Thesis too broad or too narrow
- Summarises instead of analysing
- Several unconnected claims
- Uses vague verbs: *shows*, *is about*, *explores*
- Ignores the counterarguments

Purpose and Tone Across Disciplines

Humanities	Persuasive and interpretive: argument from ideas and textual evidence
Social Sciences	Empirical and neutral: test hypotheses, describe data
Linguistics	Analytical: theory framed and tested against data
Computer Science	Technical and concise: algorithms, models, and how well they score

How Arguments Are Built

- **Humanities**: evidence supports an interpretation
- **Social Sciences**: evidence tests a hypothesis
- **Linguistics**: evidence shows a pattern or a contrast
- **Computer Science**: results must be reproducible
- **All**: say clearly what you add

Encyclopedic Writing: Wikipedia Style

- **Purpose**: inform, not argue; summarise what is accepted
- **Tone**: neutral, verifiable, non-original
- **Structure**: by topic (lead, body, appendices), see Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Layout
- **Comparison**:
  - No new data or interpretation (unlike a research paper)
  - Like the introduction of a paper: context and the key sources

Roadmap

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From Topic to Argument

- From collecting ideas to building a case
- Argue from reasons; use emotion sparingly
- Choose the kind of reasoning that fits your material
- State your conclusions with confidence, and their limits
- Let the structure show the reader your reasoning

Partly based on Ordering Evidence, Building an Argument (Allosso & Allosso, 2019, Ch. 4)

Worry about the structure more than the style

Prose is architecture, not interior decoration, and the Baroque is over.
Ernest Hemingway (1932) *Death in the afternoon*

- Foundation: a thesis and the reasons that hold it up
- Form follows function: the structure is there to make the argument clear
- The scaffolding can be invisible, but it has to be there
- A pile of points is not an argument

Outline: Before or After Drafting

- Two approaches
  - A sketch a pre-outline of controlling ideas (topic sentences)
  - B draft first, then reverse-outline to reveal the logic
- Either way, check that the essay is going somewhere
- Expect to add, cut and rearrange: nothing is fixed until the end
- Use outlines to test progression and balance

- I [FCB] normally write an outline and collect notes as I go along, then write prose at the end. I write a rough introduction first, but revise it at the end, as I almost always change many details…

Introduction, Body, Conclusion

- **Introduction**: catch interest, give the context needed, state the thesis
- **Body**: one supporting idea per paragraph
  - Transitions: each paragraph should lead to the next
  - Support: every claim gets evidence, textual or numerical
- **Conclusion**: come back to the thesis and answer: so what?

Paragraphs as Structural Beams

- Each paragraph advances one controlling idea
- Start with a topic sentence tied to the thesis
- Evidence and analysis, not a list of facts
- End by linking forward to the next step in the argument
- Cut digressions

Audience and Explicitness

- Define your terms; do not assume the reader shares your premises
- Say why the evidence matters, not just that it exists
- Be brief, but tell the reader where they are
- Clarity persuades

What you should aim for

- A logical sequence that keeps moving
- A visible line from thesis to conclusion
- Every claim supported
  - Reliable sources, correctly cited
- The emphasis falls on the central question

Acknowledgements I

- The first sections are based on Allosso and Allosso (2019)
- I also consulted Reid (2024) and Krause (2007)

Acknowledgements II

- **GPT-4o** in ChatGPT (OpenAI, 2025) was used to format the references, and generate a first draft of the slides with a prompt like

  ```
  Please make me some slides, based on Chapter 1:
  https://mlpp.pressbooks.pub/writinghandbook/chapter/chapter-1/
  Make them in LaTeX, using luatex and biber, please make around 15
  slides with at least 5 bullet points, use sub-lists where appropriate.
  ```

- I then heavily rewrote them.
- **Claude Opus 5** (Anthropic, 2026) was used to check the slides: to resolve every DOI against Crossref, fetch every URL, and compare each quotation with its original. The prompt was of the form

  ```
  Verify every claim, DOI, URL and quotation against a real source. Where you cannot
  verify something, say so rather than guessing --- never invent a reference.
  ```

  Each correction names the source it was checked against. Responsibility for what remains is mine.

References I

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Appendix

These frames are here for reference: they repeat material from another session, or go further than we had time for.

Writing Across Disciplines

- **Humanities:** build an argument through interpretation
  → *Thesis-driven essay*: claim, evidence, counterargument
- **Social Sciences:** explain social phenomena systematically
  → *IMRaD structure: Introduction → Methods → Results → Discussion*
- **Linguistics:** mix of humanities and science
  → *Intro → Background → Data/Methods → Analysis → Discussion → Conclusion*
- **Computer Science:** reproducibility, and what is new
  → *Intro → Related Work → Method → Data → Experiments/Results → Analysis → Conclusion*
- **Hybrids:** combine approaches (e.g., literature review + case study; policy analysis + recommendations)

Types of Thesis Statements

- **Analytical**: interprets and explains evidence (e.g., “The novel critiques capitalism through its fragmented narration”)
- **Expository**: explains a concept or process (useful for background essays)
- **Argumentative**: takes a position and justifies it (most common in humanities writing)
- Choose the type that fits the essay’s purpose

Summary

- A strong thesis:
  - Arises from inquiry
  - Makes a specific, arguable claim
  - Guides structure and evidence
- Expect to revise it multiple times
- Use feedback and reflection to sharpen the argument
- Every paragraph should earn its place by advancing the thesis
- Different tasks have different goals
  - You must adjust your writing style to fit the goal
  - Different disciplines have different styles

Deduction and Induction in Practice

- **Deduction**: from accepted premises to a specific conclusion

⇒ In real essays, premises are rarely beyond dispute, so state them

- **Induction**: from specific data to a generalisation; always provisional

⇒ Match the strength of the claim to the evidence

- Use both as needed; hybrid arguments are common

Finding Building Blocks

- Gather: facts, quotations, data, prior interpretations
- Note how each item functions (example, counterexample, definition)
- Separate summary from analysis in notes
- Track source details for citation and revisiting
- Drop what does not advance the claim

Sequencing and Emphasis

- Order points to create momentum (simple → complex)
- Definitions first; the fine points later
- Put your strongest section where it counts
- Use headings and transitions to signal hierarchy and shifts
- After drafting, try a different order